MINJOK HERALD

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Editor's Note

"I'm not going to do anything in KMLA. No clubs, no contests, no extracurricular activities."

Before entering the school, I was determined to live the most passive, boring, inactive school life one could imagine. And yet, as my keyboard clicks now, I find myself as the Editor-in-Chief of the Minjok Herald.

I knew there would be challenges; I knew I would be busy. I knew that perhaps my love for writing in general would not fully translate into a liking for a position that orchestrates a dynamic, creativity-filled issue of a school newspaper. I was never an adventurous person; my life motto may as well have been "Status quo."

All parts of my brain could not explain how I grew to like the Minjok Herald so much, and why I applied to be Editor-in-Chief. On the other hand, I can easily explain what I love about the Minjok Herald now, even with only a little over five months of experience as Editor-in-Chief.

Needless to mention the honorable legacy carried by the name, the Minjok Herald progresses with every new addition to our crew. The 28th wave, now juniors, have been crucial backbones of structural innovation. The 29th wavers surprise us with unprecedented creativity and unmatched enthusiasm – I have no doubt the future of Minjok Herald is in good hands.

The 70th edition delivers on the theme of "Life in the Screen," exploring how our everyday lives are being affected within one of the greatest eras of innovation. Understanding and seamlessly integrating the ever-changing technology into our lives will be key; and not to be feared, this key might open doors to new horizons unconceived even by history's greatest minds.

It is my hope that the articles pique an interest in the readers' minds to explore further upon the topic, if not arm them with useful information that will be the foundation for navigating life within the turbulent, beautiful sea of the modern world. As high schoolers, we must be ready for the future; as individuals, we must be ready for the future. In this era of innovation and progress, KMLA will change, and Minjok Herald will change – I am sure, for the better.

With the greatest hopes
27th Editor-in-Chief,
Sangmin Lee

PLAYLIST

Explore the future of sound with our AI Music Playlist.
Each track was generated with Soundraw AI.
Let these algorithmic melodies accompany you as you dive into the 70th edition of the Minjok Herald.

Adventure

Stardust

Daydream

Golden Sunrise

Silent Stars

Glide

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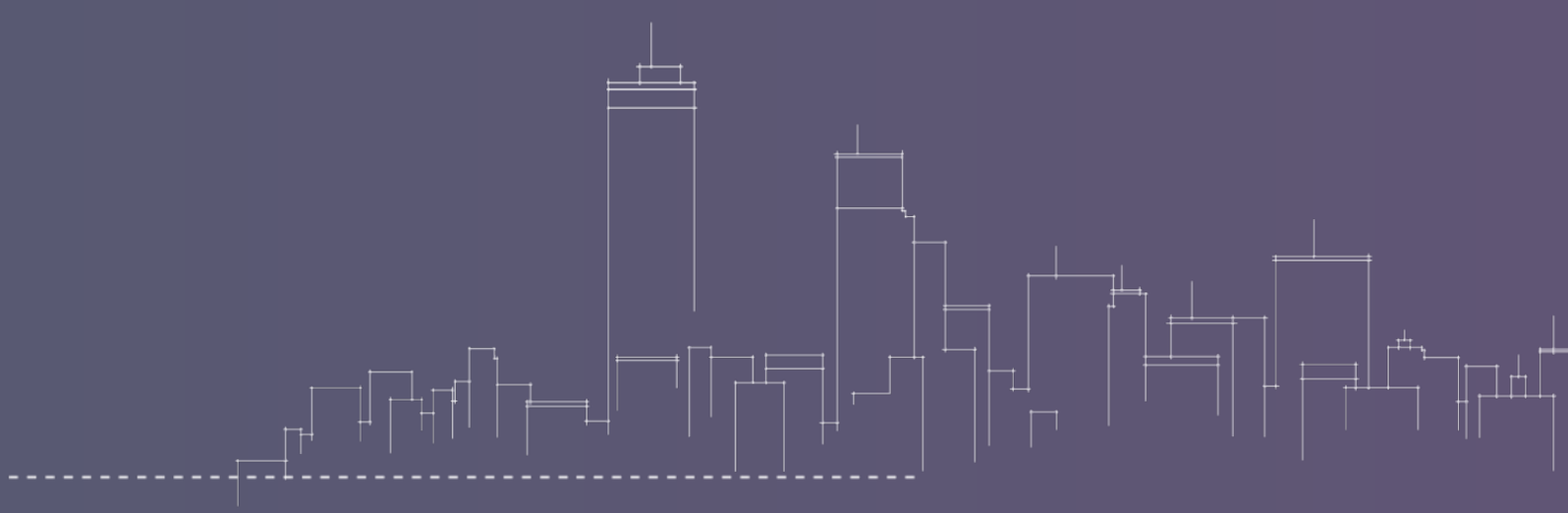

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Welcome to KMLA : Headmaster Park Ha-Shik

Suh-yoon Jahng

Dr. Park Ha-Shik, the new headmaster of our school, began his tenure in the first semester of 2024. Having served as the deputy headmaster from 1997 to 2004, Dr. Park's return marks a significant milestone for the school. His previous tenure laid the groundwork for many foundational programs. Now, he brings renewed vision and experience to the KMLA community. To introduce him and his aspirations for the school, the Minjok Herald interviewed Headmaster Park on June 18th, exploring his educational philosophies, past achievements, and future plans for KMLA's continued excellence.

MH: What was your proudest moment/achievement as an educator?

Park: The most recent moment was the 29th wavers' Vision Trip. I served as the deputy headmaster of KMLA from 1997 to 2004, and that's when I first established the Vision Trip program. I wish students could dream not only of universities in Korea but also of worldwide institutions that are the global centers of studies. This year, I visited both the Eastern and Western vision trips. Twenty years ago, I simply wished it would be great if our graduates could get employed at the companies we visited during the Vision Trip. Twenty years later, it was most rewarding to meet our graduates there as professors and researchers.

MH: What inspired or motivated you to pursue a career in education?

Park: Originally, I never thought of becoming a teacher throughout my university years. Rather, I wanted to become a pastor. I had to take education courses to fulfill my graduation requirements in my senior year of college. And I was required to participate in teaching practice. During the teaching practice period, I was deeply moved by the students' eyes filled with passion and the love that teachers showed towards the students. Then I decided to become an educator, and I have been on this path ever since.

MH: Was there a particular teacher who had a significant impact on your life?

Park: Since I decided on my career relatively late, there isn't a specific teacher who had a significant impact on my life that made me become an educator. However, Socrates and Jesus have greatly helped me shape my values and beliefs in life.

MH: What were your high school years like? How did your experiences and memories from that time influence your current work?

Park: I was a student who participated more actively in activities than in studying. Unlike the various club activities students do at our school, I was very active in church activities and spent a lot of time contemplating philosophical questions. I often deliberated on fundamental questions like "What is truth?" and "What is the nature of humanity?" This naturally led me to develop an interest in philosophy, and I decided to major in philosophy. After graduating college, I then planned to pursue theology. However, after my teaching practice experience in my senior year, I was resolved to become an educator.

MH: If you could change just one thing at KMLA right now, such as facilities, systems, or culture, what would it be?

Park: One thing I wish to accomplish is completing the unfinished buildings in our school. The plan is to establish the “General Education Building” in the vacant lot between the archery place and the gym. The "General Education Building" would include facilities like a large auditorium, library, and spaces for various types of educational activities. Establishing this building was also our founder’s dream, and I wished I could realize his dream. Even if we want to accommodate more students and teachers, there is a shortage of dormitory rooms and a lack of teacher offices. Therefore, I believe that for students to receive quality education, we would need an additional building, which is the General Education Building. Thus, though our campus is already beautiful, I dream of making it even more renowned and best-looking.

MH: How do you prepare for the morning assembly speech every Monday? How do you feel about delivering speeches in front of nearly 500 students?

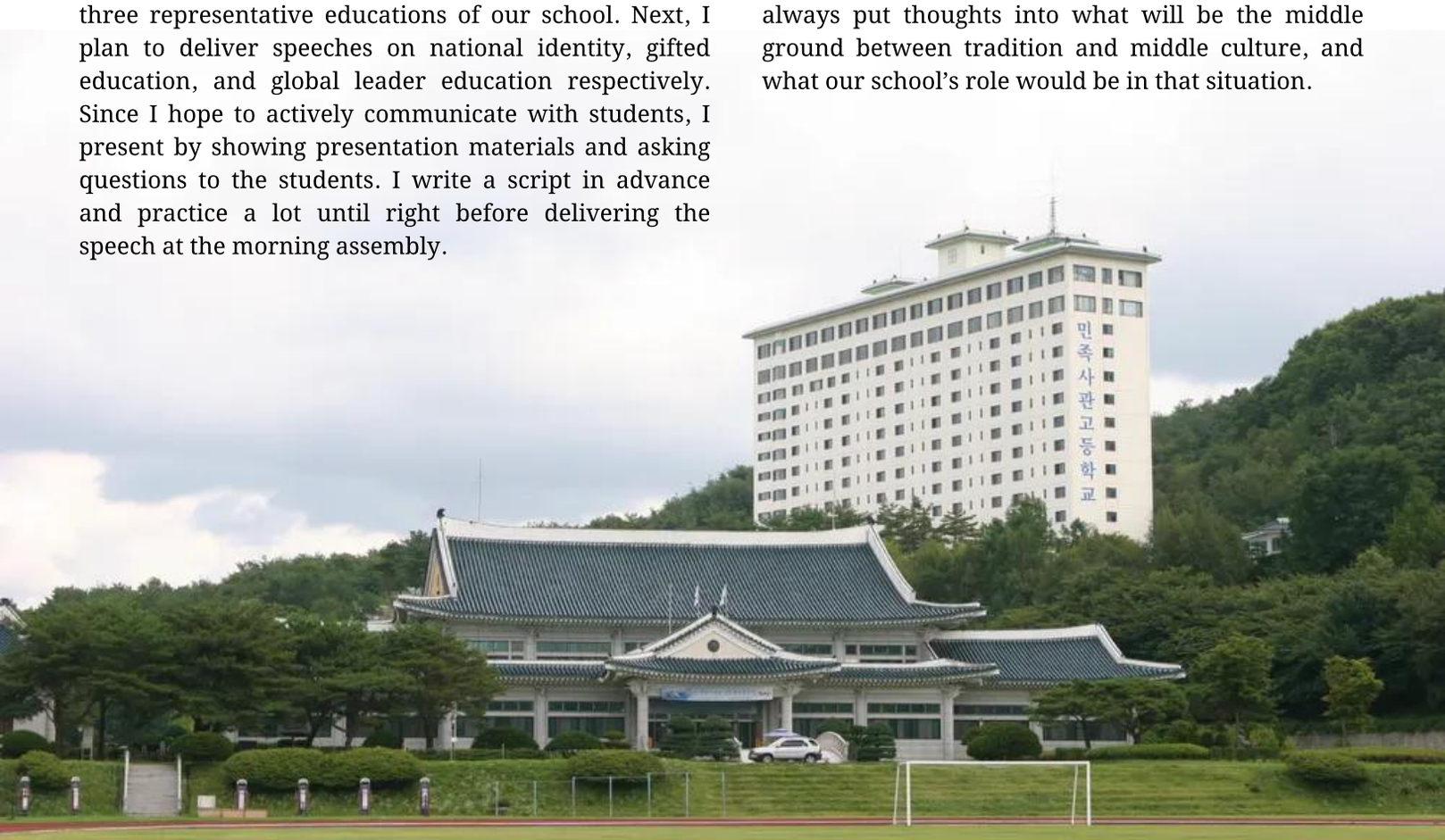
Park: Currently, I am planning a series of speeches. First, I discussed dreams. Because I believe that both teachers and students must share the values of which direction the school will take in order to progress, I wish to make students and teachers better understand the clear goals of national identity education, integrated education, and global leader education, which are the three representative educations of our school. Next, I plan to deliver speeches on national identity, gifted education, and global leader education respectively. Since I hope to actively communicate with students, I present by showing presentation materials and asking questions to the students. I write a script in advance and practice a lot until right before delivering the speech at the morning assembly.

MH: We’ve seen you taking a walk during morning exercise. What do you do at that time?

Park: At first, I only saw freshmen students practicing kendo in the gym. Because they had recently started school and were probably not used to waking up early in the morning, I wanted to encourage them. At home, parents greet you in the morning, but there is no one who could do the parent’s role at school, so I decided to greet the students. As the weather approached summer, the taekwondo kids started coming to the soccer field instead of the gym, so I started waiting for both the juniors and the taekwondo kids in front of the Deokgo House. I can tell how their school life was yesterday just by looking at students’ faces. My personal goal is to memorize the names of 450 students so that I can call them by their names when I see their faces!.

MH: Where do you think is the middle ground between tradition and modern culture?

Park: I think finding this middle ground is our school's mission. Although wearing hanbok feels awkward in places other than our school, I think that rather than thinking hanbok is uncomfortable and outdated, we should preserve our own tradition and ensure that it is not forgotten. While maintaining tradition is the mission of the school, I believe we are also operating our educational philosophy and system more modernly than any other school. I always put thoughts into what will be the middle ground between tradition and middle culture, and what our school’s role would be in that situation.



MH: What do you see yourself doing after your job/work?

Park: I think I will continue to work in the education field. After finishing my tenure as a headmaster of KMLA, I want to contribute to the globalization of Korean education. One of my interests has been the IB (International Baccalaureate) program, which I first introduced in 2014. It's only in 2024 that other schools are starting to adopt it. I believe that Korean education has more positive aspects than weaknesses, so I want to bring in foreign educational programs not to make our education dependent on them, but to show that Korean education can set global standards. That's why I believe it's the duty of educators to work towards this goal.

MH: If you could choose one word to describe your life, what would that word be?

Park: My email ID is sonsin0628. "Sonsin" isn't a word, but it's a nom de plume I gave myself when I was in college. It is a word consisting of two Chinese characters each meaning humility and faith. While seeking truth with a humble heart, since I identify myself as Christian, I wish I wouldn't lose my faith in Christianity. The word “Sonsin” can explain the way I view my life.

MH: Finally, do you have any words you'd like to say to the students?

Park: I have come up with a slogan for our school. It is "Pride of Korean Education, KMLA." I believe that our school's students will become the hope of our country and those who will brighten the future. When I have meetings with people near Hoengseong, they say that after drinking with friends and driving home, they see the KMLA dormitory brightly lit up to the 12th floor late at night. It made them reflect on their own actions of drinking and think that "the future of Korea is there at KMLA." So I wish the students to have pride in both themselves and the school, and become individuals who will light up Korea’s bright future.

Embracing Tradition and Vision: The 29th Entrance Ceremony at KMLA

Suh-yoon Jahng

On March 1st, the 29th Entrance Ceremony, the inaugural ceremony of the 9th Headmaster, and the 105th Anniversary of the Samil Independence Movement were held at KMLA. The ceremony was held at the gym, filled with teachers, families, juniors, and seniors who were there to congratulate the official entrance of the new wave.

The entrance ceremony started with the opening parade of Samuchim, KMLA's traditional music club. Starting from the Chungmoo building, teachers, led by the parade, walked into the gym. After singing the national anthem and the school motto, two students, Oh Seung-Chan, and Lee So-Myung, and two teachers, Ms. Kwak So-Hyun and Mr. Lee Ye-Jun stood at the podium reciting the Declaration of Independence of Korea. As the teachers and students read the Declaration, everyone in the gym reflected on their patriotic spirits.

The highlight of the ceremony was the candlelight ceremony. Mr. Yang Dong-Hyuk walked into the gym with his candle lit. Students lit up their own candles and then passed the flame to the person next to them.

After every candle was lit, they carefully walked to the front where they could place their candles on a stand. The flickering and glittery lights made the students ruminate about the significance of the candlelight spirit.

After the candlelight ceremony, students from class 10, representing the 29th wavers, stood at the podium reciting their 29th wave KMLA Declaration. The declaration was solely written by students, conveying their hopes and strong resolve to always have passion and integrity, and to be a global leader committed to the world.

The 29th wave's entrance ceremony was especially meaningful because it was also the inaugural ceremony of the 9th headmaster, Park Ha-Shik, who used to be the first vice principal of our school. He established the AP system for our school and organized systems for international students to study abroad. His inaugural speech encapsulated his strong will and vision to make KMLA the light and hope for Korea. He also wished for parents and teachers' support to trust him and his students.

28th waver Paik In-Seo was truly delighted to have a new wave entering. “It still doesn’t feel real that I’m a junior and I’m getting to meet new hoobaes. But I am very proud to have new freshmen coming to our school, and I’m looking forward to the life we’ll have with our freshmen.” She also wished good luck to the new start of the 29th wavers’ school lives.

29th waver Lee Ju-Eun expressed her excitement, as well as some worries. “Time flies! Our February was full of struggles to get used to the new school. I am a little overwhelmed about navigating through these situations. But the school that I’ve experienced through our Orientation period was a place full of bright laughter and excitement, so I am looking forward to my school life.” She also mentioned how she feels like a part of the KMLA family and that KMLA has become “her school.”

Life in KMLA will be a series of joy, pride, sadness, and disappointments. The next three years ahead may not be smooth sailing, but we hope you find something you truly like and make unforgettable high school memories with friends that will last for a lifetime.

Congratulations on becoming a part of the KMLA family. Welcome to KMLA, freshmen!

Photo Credit:
28th Waver Yewon Kim

Humans of Minsa

#humansofminsa #minjokherald

In April of 2014, one of KMLA's longest-standing Facebook pages began and gradually accrued more than 1.5K followers over many years of dutiful continuation. In an effort to potentially bring this page back to life, MH has been paying tribute to Humans of Minsa (https://www.facebook.com/HumansofMinsa) over the spring semester by conducting short human-centric interviews with randomly encountered members of the KMLA family, hoping to make it an ongoing trend that will tighten the school community.

For those unfamiliar with the concept of Humans of Minsa, it followed on the heels of many similar Facebook pages that sprung up after "Humans of New York" (https://www.facebook.com/humansofnewyork) became a viral sensation in 2010. The movement was started by Brandon Stanton, a photographer and former bond trader who lost his job and decided to pursue his passion for photography. Armed with a camera, he started taking portraits of strangers on the streets of New York City and asking them questions about their lives, emphasizing storytelling and empathy. To this day it continues as a global phenomenon and often changes the lives of those featured on it. While Humans of Minsa can only hope to have this kind of impact, at the very least we hope that these articles offer a deeper glimpse into what it's like to be a student at KMLA and how our journeys take shape.

28th Waver Yeonsoo Chu

"The trap is that we tend to think too much before we even act. I think we should live with minimum meaning in life."

It's sort of a unique belief I have; being thoughtless. Normally, we think we need to think, reflect, judge, and evaluate a lot. The trap is that we tend to think too much before we even act. I think we should live with minimum meaning in life.

That might be controversial for many. What I'm saying is: that when you're going through hardships, you have to have the courage to just not think, because more often than not, we use it as an excuse to not act.

I strive to stay consistent and do it regularly. Adjustable consistency gives it meaning when it feels meaningless, so you can bear hardship better and overcome difficulties.

29th Waver
Somin Lee

" I've seen a lot of truly amazing people at KMLA, and next year I want to be that kind of person to someone else."

"I want to be someone that shines. I used to say that I want to be a bright person, but I think I've achieved that, so from now on, I want to go further and be someone that shines. I've seen a lot of truly amazing people at KMLA, and next year I want to be that kind of person to someone else.

'Challenge' is the value that I place the most importance on. My goal in life currently is that when I turn 80 and I look back on my life, I don't want to have any regrets. At any point in our lives, the possibilities are endless and there are always infinite new paths waiting for us."

Being at KMLA has transformed me as a person incredibly and so far, KMLA has truly been a meaningful, life-changing experience. When someone asks me in the future, "What was the most significant time in your life?" I want my answer to be my high school years in KMLA."

28th Waver
Jia Lee

"My legacy is that I can surf on the waves everyday."

Before coming to KMLA, I didn't have a vivid goal or a dream.My journey in KMLA taught me the importance of balance and undergoing hardships. The waves are unpredictable just like how it is in life. Living is about handling and overcoming these uncomfortable situations that are coming up to us like waves. Therefore, I think my legacy is to have the opportunity to actually find these waves that I can surf on and enjoy them.

There are two main characteristics I want to have as an adult in the future. First, an adult who never gives up due to hardships. Second, an adult who has careness and compassion for people both near and far who needs our help. I want to be a person who can give support to as many people as possible. Especially for the people who don't have a substitute for achieving their goals.

28th Waver Yuju Lee

"The most recent happiest moment?
The most recent hottest topic was the giveaway of snacks from a peer counseling club, Soksakim."

"The most recent happiest moment? The most recent hottest topic was the giveaway of snacks from a peer counseling club, Soksakim. Well, this may be the first experience for the 29th wavers, but we, Soksakim, give away snacks for students as a method to cheer them up every exam season."

In the past, we had attached some quotes that encourage students by searching through the Internet. This year, one of our club members gave a nice idea to actually print the words of teachers in our school instead of quotes searched from the Internet. In the process, I encountered and talked with teachers that I had never seen before, and was also able to sense that the teachers were rooting for the students for real. The process of printing their quotes and sticking them on snack boxes was truly challenging and time-consuming. However, the students' reactions were very positive, making me feel rewarded.

27th Waver Jungwon Shin

"I want to change our stance; why change nature when we can just improve ourselves?"

"I want to change our stance; why change nature when we can just improve ourselves?"
The more I learned about our environment and ecosystem, the more I fell in love with them and started to wonder exactly how I could help our world.

People often try to find ways to change the environment in order for humans and nature to live peacefully together. However, I wanted to find ways for people to change in order to preserve nature as it is now. And that is why I became interested in the medical field, and I now hope to research cancer and our immune systems to help achieve my dream.

HISTORY OF MINSA:
The Abandoned Building, Changuiguan

Daeun Song

Among the most trending words of 2023, “liminal” refers to empty or transitional spaces that evoke a sense of unease or nostalgia. In a psychological sense, the “liminal” feeling often describes moments of transition in life or ambiguous emotional states. Image search “liminal” and you’ll find abandoned theme parks, empty hotel corridors, and swimming pools without swimmers. Millennials often hunt for liminal spaces for this unique feeling, and Mr. Ganse treated MH to it generously as he guided us through the mysterious hallways of Changuigwan, KMLA’s abandoned dormitory.

While Deokgogwan houses every student today, 20 years ago it was Changuigwan, built in 1997, where students - all boys - spent their hours sleeping and studying. At the time, girls stayed in what is now the English Building, and after Deokgogwan was constructed, the boys moved there, and the girls switched to Changuigwan. Eventually, when all students began staying at Deokgogwan, Changuigwan became a venue for summer and winter camps.

Changuigwan consists of 3 floors above ground with a cafeteria on the first basement level. Behind the building, there used to be a swimming pool, though the water was filled only twice in its entire history. Adjacent to the pool was a barbecue area. It is noteworthy that the barbecue area was located right next to the dormitory, unlike today where barbecue areas are separate from the dormitories. Additionally, stones for future Nobel Prize winners were installed on the left side of the building.

Upon entering with Mr. Ganse as our guide, the first sight was desks with computers. The lobby appears to be almost half the size of the Dasan Hall lobby. On the lower level, the first basement housed the cafeteria and kitchen. The kitchen was where 40 students were fed 28 years ago, with only occasional use during camps ever since. The cafeteria, still comfortable and inviting, exists next to a room with desks and a chair, its former use unknown. Entering the hallway, there is a laundry room.

Furthermore, we discovered an interesting story related to the building. Second graders jog for morning exercise, and sometimes they take a walk to Changuigwan. Along the way, a mysterious trail with 8 lines is striped on the road. Mr. Ganse related that these lines were intended to heat the road to prevent unlucky girls from slipping in winter. If you look closely, you may see iron rods which were used for the heating system.

Although Changuigwan is no longer in use and many students are even unaware of its existence, it has its own unique story. Exploring and imagining the lives of our alumni who spent time there allows us to appreciate its history. While visiting Changuigwan might feel a bit “liminal” at first, it is also a rewarding journey that reminds one of how rich and diverse KMLA’s history truly is. What does the future hold for this building? Dear readers, how about finding new and effective ways to utilize it and create new stories?

Vision Trip

EAST COAST

Jeongmin Lee

The students rushed out of their dormitories at 4:00 in the morning, buzzing with excitement as they got on the bus that would take them to what they'd been looking forward to for months: the Vision Trip. A 10-day trip in a country across the Pacific Ocean, the United States of America.

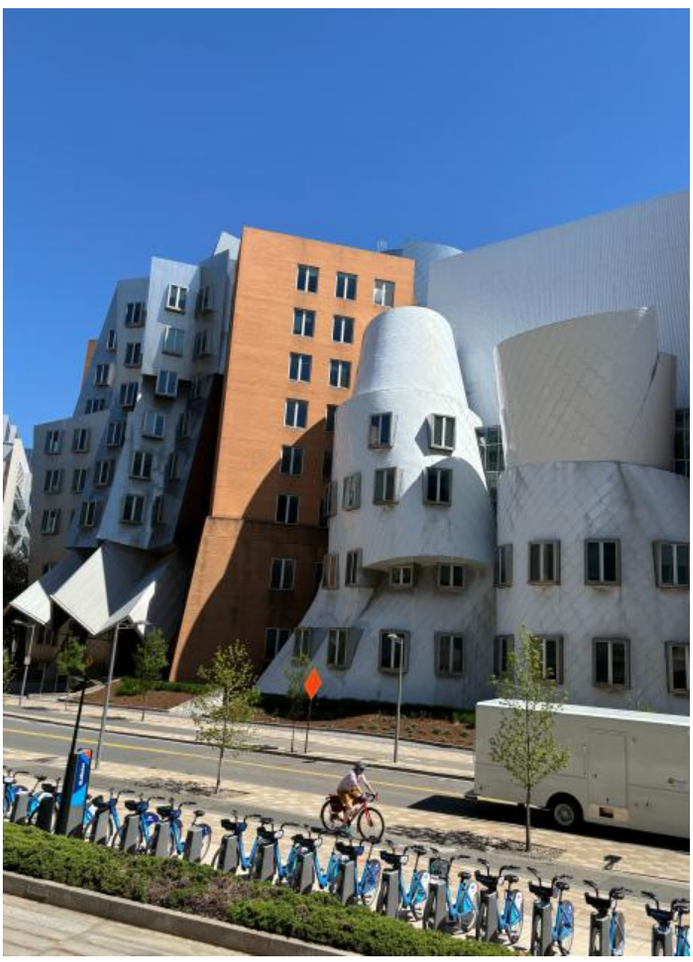
10:00 AM, the students board the plane. The 29th wavers fly over beautiful scenery for the next 14 hours, and whoever looked outside would have seen bright stars dotting the pitch black sky, raw and unblurred; a glimpse of what lies ahead.

The plane lands. Songs about New York start playing softly as the pilot informs the passengers that we have arrived. We are finally here!

UNIVERSITIES

"This isn't just a vacation, it's a *Vision Trip*."

The purpose of freshmen going on these Vision Trips is to find their 'vision'; a clearer idea of what they want their future to look like. To say the highlight of the Vision Trip is going on campus tours and meeting our alumni wouldn't be a stretch. That is exactly what the students on the East Coast did, and what does the East Coast have that the West Coast (arguably) doesn't? That's right, about eight of the most renowned universities in all of America. Out of the many prestigious colleges, the 29th wavers visited the following: Princeton, Swarthmore, University of Pennsylvania, Yale, Brown, Olin, and MIT. Unfortunately, we were not able to visit Columbia and Harvard University due to the ongoing protests for Palestinian emancipation. Even at the other universities, students were protesting in tents holding up signs, protesting Israel with claims of genocide.



Students were able to get an idea of the unique characteristics of each university through campus tours with the university students, info sessions, and Q&As with KMLA alumni. The alumni also gave us a lot of advice for college applications and general school life.

The American system was quite different from Korea in that it allowed students to change, drop, or add majors freely. Unlike in Korea, university students in the US typically choose their majors in their junior years, mostly exploring different fields in a loose 'intended major' frame as freshmen and sophomores. The alumni also gave us tips and insight on their admission processes.

24th waver Choi Seo-Yeon said to the students "While pain is sometimes a necessary part of growth, it is crucial to safeguard yourself to avoid deep scars." In an environment that makes anything less than perfect feel like something to be ashamed of, her words reminded us that we don't always have to feel bad about our imperfections; instead, we can choose to accept and love them.

FOOD

Visiting universities, although highly beneficial to our growth and success as proud KMLA students, can be exhausting. By now, we should be getting some food, right?

The food during the Vision Trip was, for lack of a better description, very, very American. Oftentimes, our meals were salty, oily, and absolutely huge. Notably, the Philly Cheesesteaks were like forearms that were double the diameter. We also observed that Americans seemed to love cheese. All this is not to say the food was necessarily bad; we ate plenty of delicious things. Nonetheless, the food in general provided generous stimuli for our Korean taste buds.

America had fantastic desserts, though. When we went to Walmart and Target, we were able to see aisles and aisles of American snacks. There were many sugary confectioneries such as sugar cookies and colorful cupcakes. There was also a wider range of sodas available. The soda machine at one university, which had a screen providing reportedly over a hundred different flavors, was memorable to a lot of students.

TOURISM

The tourist attractions of the East Coast did not disappoint. In New York, the students were split up into three groups, two going to see Wicked and Aladdin on Broadway, and the other going to an MLB game.

The musicals were a magical experience. In Wicked, the actress playing Elphaba blew us all away with her Broadway vocals. The number ‘Defying Gravity’ left everyone speechless from her stage presence and the breathtaking stage scenery, which made her look like she was genuinely flying, carrying the buzzing excitement through the entire intermission.

We were able to choose between the Metropolitan Museum of Art and the Museum of Modern Art(MoMA). Each had countless beautiful works by some of the most famous artists in the world. It was impossible to enjoy everything given the short time frame, but that isn’t to say it wasn’t a meaningful time for everyone.

On the way there, we caught a glimpse of people preparing for the 2024 Met Gala, which was held on May 6th – just two days after we saw it! We saw a lot of world-famous stores and facilities while passing through New York, having the students endlessly clicking their camera shutters in an attempt to take a photo from inside a moving bus.

Nothing could prepare us for the gasp when we saw the New York skyline behind the glorious Statue of Liberty – and the strong wind of the cruise ship didn’t help much. Hats and hair and people were being quite literally blown away while we tried to keep ourselves presentable for a photo. Some stood at the front, reenacting the famous scene from Titanic. We listened to the guide singing a song while we all gaped at the Statue, standing tall and proud before our eyes.

OH NO!

Now, no school trip is complete without a few curveballs here and there. This year's Vision Trip was one of trial and error, as has been and will be for Vision Trips to come.

Our journey was quite eventful even before stepping foot out of JFK Airport and onto American land. Notably, one student lost their passport at the airport. Another got caught at the immigration inspection, but luckily got back to the group safely.

There was also an incident where a student lost an envelope containing $700 while we were enjoying pizza at Central Park. We can only hope that whoever found it needed it.

Some students became the victims of a bird's unfortunately timed bowel movements. We at Minjok Herald give our condolences to those who were attacked by American bird poop. May their futures be bright and their lives free, just as the bird poops.

Times Square was a minefield for us students. There were people dressed as cartoon characters, offering – more so demanding – pedestrians a photo for who knows how much money. The pungent smell of marijuana drugs hung in the atmosphere, mixing with the bright luminescence of the gigantic billboards that filled the scene.

Another group of students ordered delivery to their hotel, getting caught by a teacher. Hopefully, they at least had a chance to enjoy the food first.

Hopefully, these mistakes and happenings will become sweet memories that make the 2024 Vision Trip even more special to remember. Just as the great Bob Ross once said, "There are no mistakes, only happy accidents."

MISCELLANEOUS

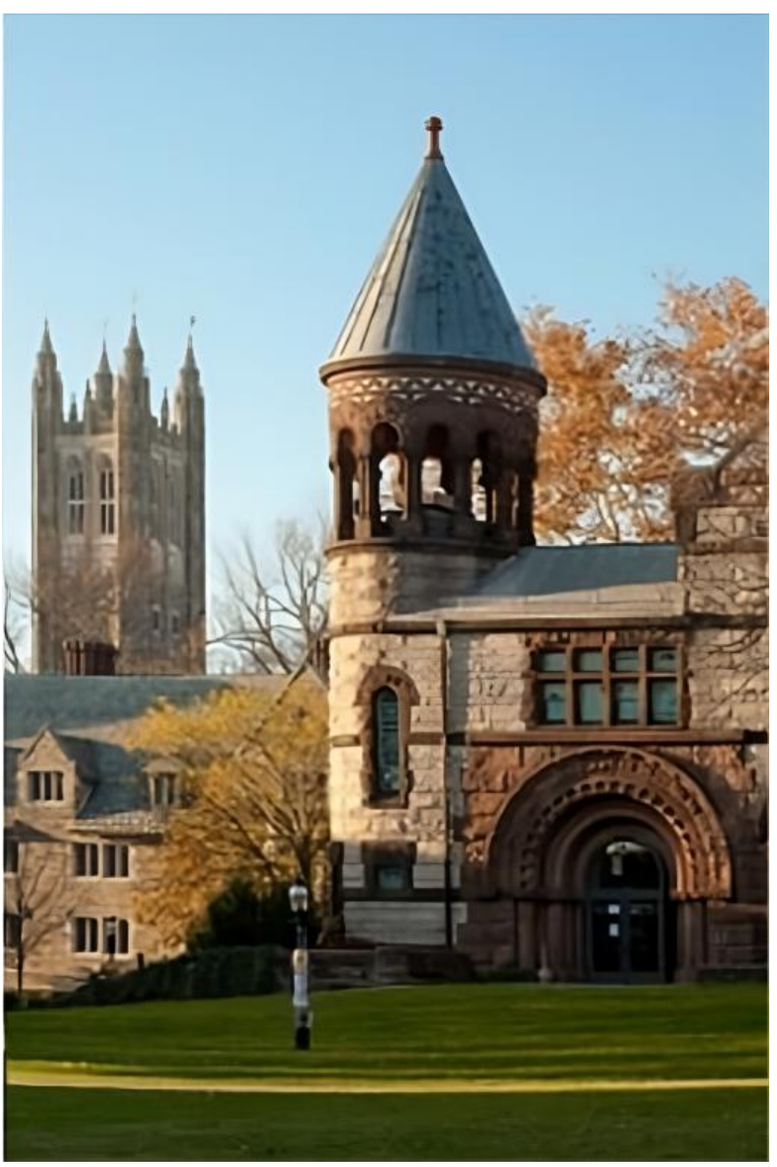
This Vision Trip couldn't possibly be contained in four categories, so we've gathered some extra to give readers a slice-of-life point of view of our memories.

Student Kim Geon-Woo met an elderly stranger near the Harvard bookstore and played a game of chess with him. The man wanted to bet money, to which Kim refused, explaining he was a student. He said that the man frustrated him with his unprofessional chess playing, and Kim ended up losing the game.

In Boston, some of the students enjoyed a street performance by a violinist. She played famous pop songs with incredible skill, and the students sang along and danced. In the end, there was quite a crowd of KMLA students enjoying the performance. When it was time to go, the violinist took a photo with us and gave us her Instagram.

Our visit to MIT was quite interesting as well. One alumnus gave his group bananas from the MIT lounge, which we happily ate. There were also two geese idly existing on the grass. Speaking of grass, grass in the US was surprisingly clean compared to Korea. Unlike in Korea where we are always wary of mites, we could lie down and roll around in the grass.

So, how did we record our Vision Trip? For the East Coast, Mr. Yang Dong-Hyuk had the students choose between filming at least three YouTube shorts and writing an essay. Many videos were uploaded to the Vision Trip YouTube channel, and one video even hit 5.9k views.



CONCLUSION

Nothing lasts forever. The 2024 Vision Trip inevitably came to an end.

As the plane rose, the scene we were all a part of just a few hours before became a brilliant map of city lights, drifting away inch by inch.

When the plane got high enough, the sky once again was filled with stars.
The closest star to our Solar System is 4.24 light-years away. That's more than 40 trillion kilometers away. Still, their light decorates our sky every night, shining just as bright as the day before.
The Vision Trip was an opportunity for growth for everyone, although it may be in different ways. It may not have led us to realize exactly what we want to do with our lives. But what is certain is that all of these experiences have allowed us to grow into the people we are today. One day, we will all grow up to be like those stars we see in the sky; our glow reaching even those hundreds of light-years away, lighting up the world with our unique colors.

Vision Trip

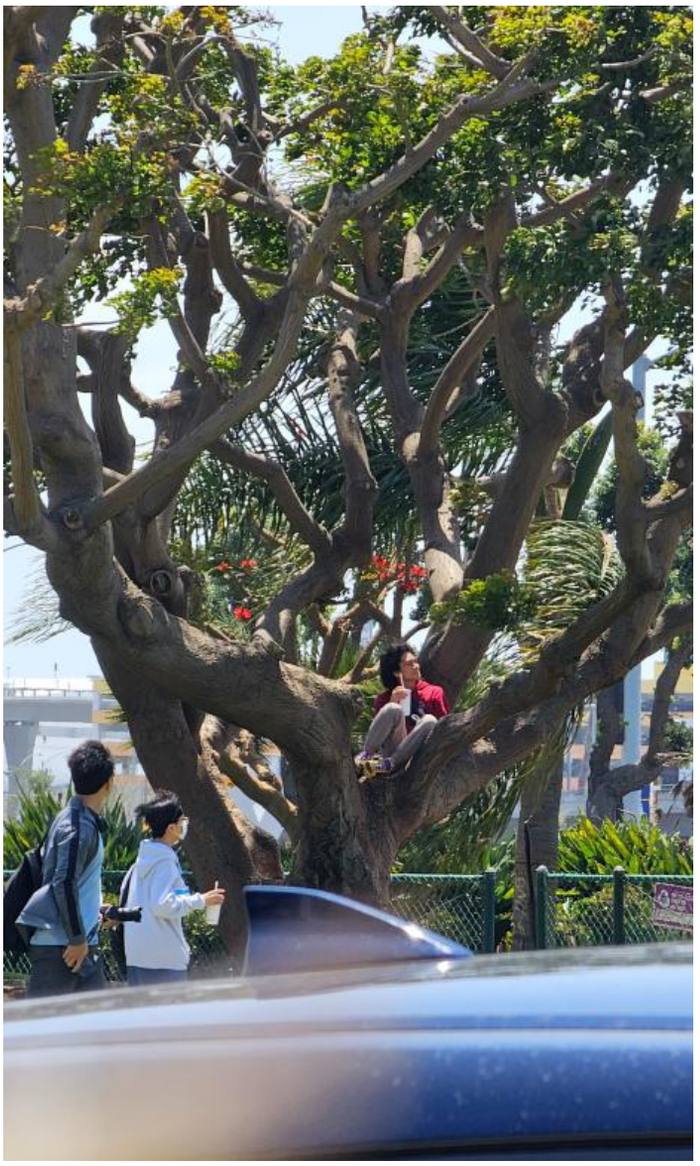
WEST COAST

Jeongheon Lee

A light in the darkness. A brief respite from the pains of everyday life. Everyone has that special something, and for the 29th wave of KMLA, it was the Vision Trip. From as early as February, when students first stepped into KMLA life, excitement for the Vision Trip was palpable. After all, how many schools take their students overseas to the United States? But the anticipation had to wait, as students first faced their initial high school exams. Amidst the new experiences at KMLA, students kept their spirits high with the thought of the Vision Trip. Perhaps when spirits were lowest due to midterms, the 29th wave embarked on their much-anticipated journey.

On the first of May, the Western group left the structured environment of KMLA around 7:30 AM and explored the duty-free shops at Incheon Airport. Despite some confusion during ticketing, resulting in ‘no seats available,’ the guides' assistance ensured everyone boarded the plane. By 3 PM, the 29th wavers were high in the sky, their spirits soaring even higher.

UNIVERSITIES & GOOGLE/META



Teachers often emphasized that the Vision Trip wasn't just a "school trip" but a journey to find our vision. To that end, we visited numerous universities on the West Coast: USC, UCLA, CMC, Pomona, Caltech, UC Berkeley, and Stanford. Despite protests related to the situation in Palestine threatening our visits, we managed to see all the universities safely. Students were amazed by the expansive and green campuses, a stark contrast to Korean universities.

However, what made these visits special were the KMLA alumni at each school who introduced their institutions and offered advice. Their presence filled us with pride for our school and highlighted the prestigious nature of KMLA. Alumni provided personal insights, though time constraints often led Mr. Kang Mun-Guen to cut Q&A sessions short, much to the disappointment of students eager to visit the Caltech bookstore. A particularly memorable quote from a UC Berkeley alumnus, "To someone who has a vision, nothing is coincidental," resonated deeply, bringing us closer to finding our own visions.

We didn't just visit universities; KMLA alumni also had influence beyond academia. Many worked at Google and Meta, and we were split into groups to visit these companies. Unlike typical tours, alumni guided us through deeper parts of the companies, showcasing their exceptional welfare programs and inspiring many of us to aspire to work there, bringing us another step closer to our visions.

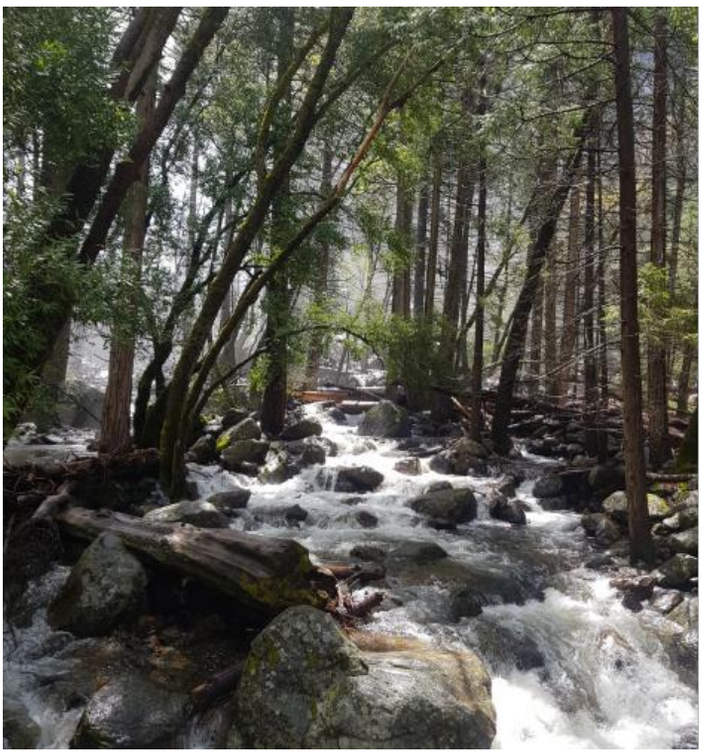
FOOD

Before continuing our vision-finding mission, we took a lunch break. Enthusiastic and hungry, our first "American" meal was burgers from In & Out. We enjoyed them in a quintessentially American way, sitting on the grass or by trees, feeling the wind from planes overhead. Contrary to our expectations of salty food, we found the fries "the opposite of salty- the fries were really lame."

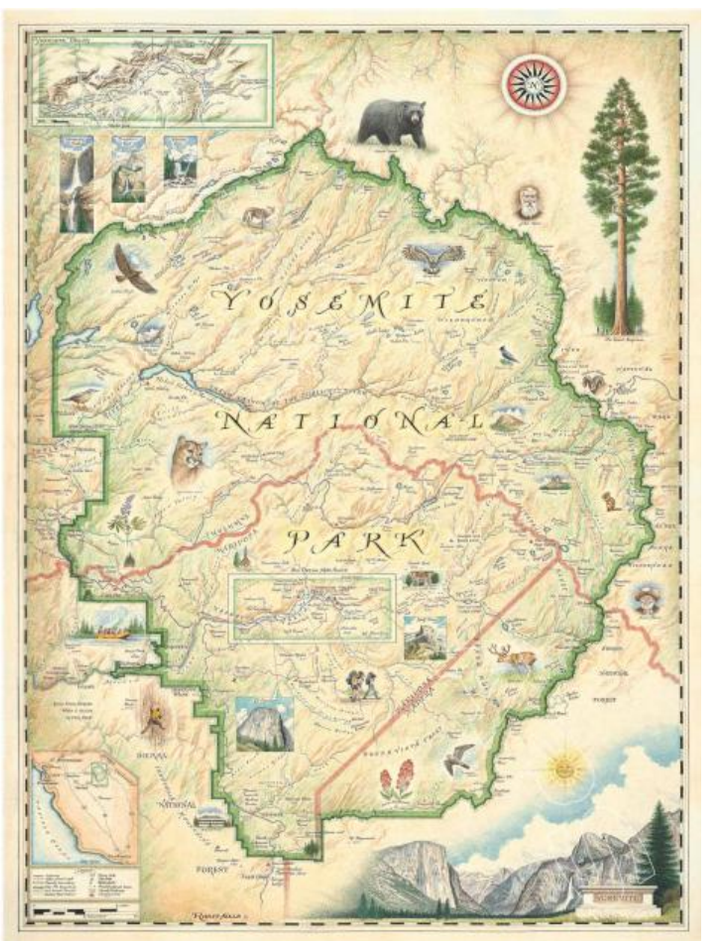
Despite being in the US, we remained Koreans at heart. Most of our meals were at an Asian buffet, which was somewhat disappointing. Traveling so far only to eat familiar food, prepared less expertly, wasn't ideal. "No words.. for that... food," some remarked. Perhaps next year's students will get to savor more authentic American cuisine.

TOURIST PLACES

While finding 'Vision' at universities was essential, the Vision 'Trip' also involved exploring iconic tourist spots. The highlight was Yosemite National Park, especially Tunnel View, which was breathtaking. The most unforgettable experience was getting soaked by the grand waterfalls. The falls weren't just a sight; they were an experience. The powerful water felt like freedom, washing away all our worries and stress. These attractions were integral to the 'vision' part of the trip, perhaps even more so than the universities.



OH NO!



No trip is perfect, and the Vision Trip had its share of hiccups. At Incheon Airport, Lee Jeong-Heon's mother unexpectedly showed up to bring him a replacement phone and money he had mistakenly packed in checked baggage, causing a delay.

"Well, I had broken my phone in the bathroom the weekend before Vision Trip. The phone just wouldn't work! So I told my mom, and on the day of the Vision Trip, she came all the way from Seoul to Incheon with a phone Dad had been using a couple of years ago, something that was literally just rolling on the ground. I thought that was it, but it turned out I had put all my money in the checked baggage, so I had to take them out, and the employee told me it would take an hour. So I waited an hour with my mom while nearly all of the students had entered the duty-free zone. After taking the money out, I had lunch separately with my mom, too. Then I went to the duty-free zone, 2 to 3 hours late. But to be honest, spending some time with my mom was a special experience."

In Los Angeles, Kum Sa-In was detained due to a discrepancy between his appearance and ID photo, delaying our schedule. "When we arrived in the US, we waited for Sa-In, but he didn't come. We were angry, but when he explained, we couldn't help but laugh," recalled Bae Jun-Yeong. Sa-In's explanation of being mistaken for someone else added humor to the situation in hindsight.

MISCELLANEOUS

A historical moment occurred on this Vision Trip. For the first time, Mr. Kim Myung-Soon and several students ran across the entirety of the Golden Gates Bridge. “In the past waves, we didn't even have the chance to run across the bridge. Last year, I ran half of it and came back by myself. But this year I asked for this program—to get across the bridge—and the 29th wave is the first to go across the entire bridge with me. I feel very proud of us all.” Mr. Kim said, running on the bridge, “Doesn't it feel like freedom? As if you've got the whole world?”

CONCLUSION

Everything comes and goes, and so did the Vision Trip. Ten days felt both long and short, but we returned to South Korea and KMLA. Experiences matter because they leave a mark, a trace that can change one’s life. The Vision Trip left such a trace for the 29th wavers. Before the trip, it was merely a hopeful thought, a light in the darkness. Now, that light is within us, a flashlight we hold. It’s no longer just a dream; it’s reality, giving us the vision to navigate through darkness ourselves. Everyone’s vision is unique, making the Vision Trip special. It’s not just our trip, but each individual's journey to find their vision. As we face future challenges, we now have the vision to overcome them. Remember, “To someone who has a vision, nothing is coincidental.” 29th wavers, it’s time to turn on the flashlight.

Vision Trip Extras: Available in QR

An Unexpected Chess Encounter at Harvard

SCAN ME

During a break at Harvard, 29th waver Kim Geon-Woo stumbled upon an old man playing chess and felt an intense urge to join him. Despite not having played for six years, Kim eagerly accepted the challenge, and they agreed to play without betting. The game revealed the old man's unconventional style and lack of formal chess rules, which initially frustrated Kim. Despite employing the 'Alpha pair' technique, Kim lost the match. This encounter reignited his passion for chess, motivating him to play more regularly and possibly compete again, appreciating the unpredictable and creative aspects of the game of chess.

University Tour Amid Campus Protests

The Vision Trip faced unexpected challenges due to student protests over the Israel-Palestinian war. Starting in April, these protests disrupted university tours, with campuses like Columbia and Harvard closing down. At Columbia, protests escalated, leading to police involvement and campus lockdowns. Despite these disruptions, the trip's essence remained intact. In Central Park, students and over 20 alumni engaged in meaningful discussions, sharing insights and reflections. We interviewed Park Ha-Young, a Columbia senior, who provided a deep dive into the protests' complexities, student activism, and the broader implications for university life and global awareness.

SCAN ME

Discover Choi Seo-Yeon's Journey at UPenn

SCAN ME

Meet Choi Seo-Yeon, a KMLA 24th waver and rising junior at UPenn. Initially applying without high expectations, Choi found her niche in the Vagelos MLS program, which offers research stipends and networking for natural science students. She praises UPenn's interdisciplinary programs, such as Penn LSM, Huntsman, and VIPER, for blending various fields and providing alumni connections. She also values the structured learning approach and supportive academic environment, where mutual respect enhances the experience. Recently, Choi changed her major, a journey detailed in the full interview. Discover her inspiring story and insights into UPenn’s unique offerings.

The Messy Tradition of "Ben on The Bench"

The Benjamin Franklin statue on Locust Walk, affectionately known as “Ben on The Bench,” is central to one of UPenn’s oldest and messiest traditions: public urination. Since the fall semester began, six individuals have been cited for urinating near the statue, though many others evade police. One student recounted how he and his friends, after a frat party, were caught by campus security, resulting in a citation for a friend. Despite campus security efforts and Penn's cameras, the tradition persists, especially during heavy drinking periods like New Student Orientation. The statue requires frequent cleaning, straining Penn’s maintenance resources.

SCAN ME

FAREWELL TO OUR BELOVED BAKER:

Honoring Mr. Hwang Oh-Seop's 25-Year Legacy

Daeun Song

Whenever we feel longing, compunctious, and fall into callosity during life in KMLA, at 9:00 pm, a soft and tender smell from the 12th floor leads us to where the 'honjeong bread' is. The bread, along with the milk comforts us and brings our mood back to positivity.

Not many students knew there was a hidden figure who had preserved our happiness during all this time. For 25 years, Mr. Hwang Oh-Seop, the baker at KMLA, worked with the belief that students should be able to study with a healthy mind. But alas, Mr. Hwang is retiring after having baked more than 300 kinds of bread, spending more than 6 hours every day, 7 days a week, for 10 months a year.

To repay his love, on June 28th, students of our school gathered to celebrate his retirement and show gratitude for his dedication. Students prepared a rolling paper where they wrote thank-yous and other kind words. A ceremony was held at 1 pm in the cafeteria; students and teachers gathered in front of the bakery, delivered rolling paper, and gave him a big applause.

He expressed his impression of retirement: He advised students to study hard with a healthy mind, truly believing that KMLA students could become global leaders.

After the ceremony, Minjok Herald could have a chance to briefly interview him.

He spoke about his devotion to work, emphasizing a commitment to using the best ingredients and maintaining optimal storage conditions. Even after undergoing three to four surgeries, he continued to set up the bread every week. His scars bear testimony to the challenges he faced during his 25 years as KMLA's baker. He fondly recalled students' favorite breads and expressed his love for them. His final message to the students was, "You are doing great now. As you excel in your school life, you will likely become great adults. So, stay healthy always."

Mr. Hwang is now taking a well-deserved break. Though his retirement is bittersweet, his legacy and the warmth of his bread will continue to resonate in the cafeteria. We bid him farewell with a bright smile as he embarks on this new chapter. Our new baker, Mr. Park Jong Min, who has trained for several months, will continue the tradition of baking with love for the students.

Let's give a final big round of applause to Mr. Hwang Oh-Seop, whose breads were always a great joy for us students.

EDITORIAL

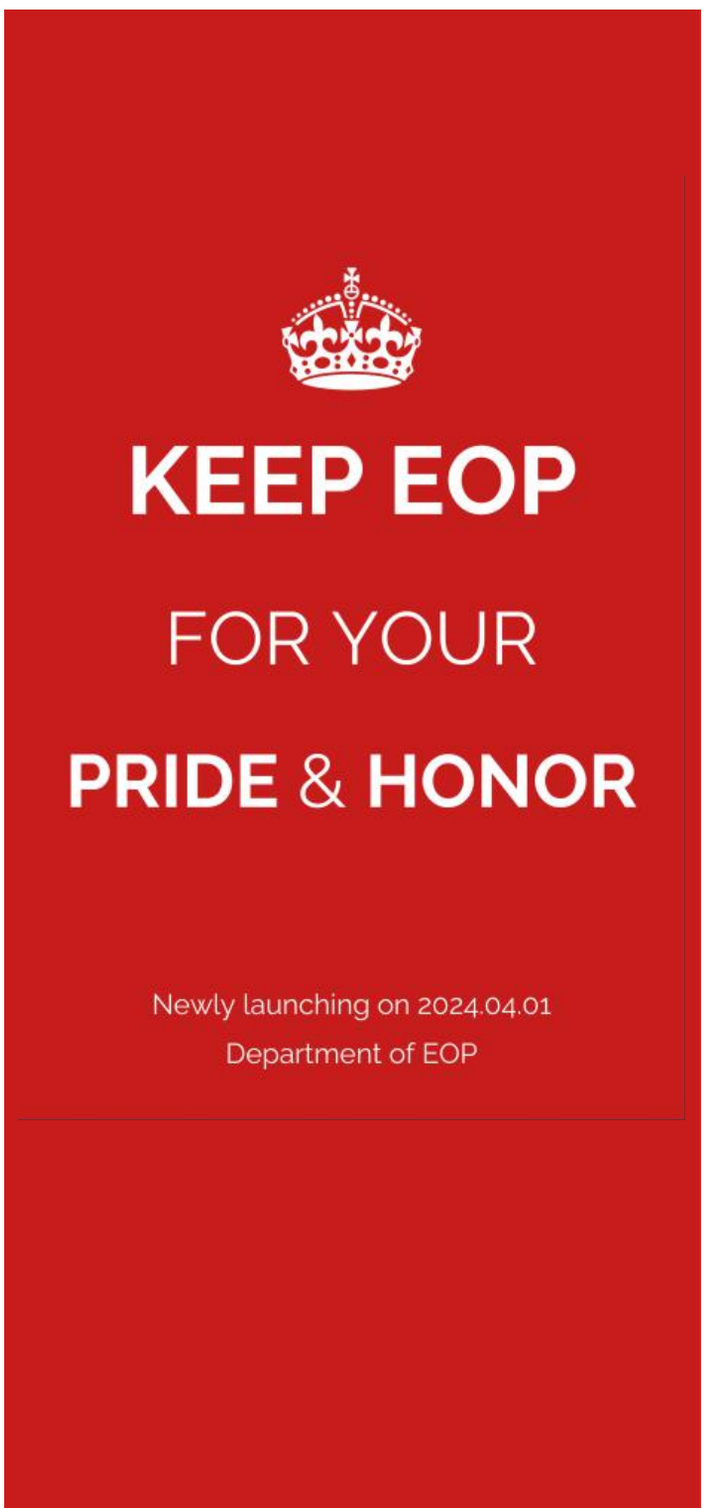
"All great changes are preceded by chaos," Deepak Chopra said.

Indeed, significant consequences are followed by a series of changes. It's about how well we cope with and move on to the next step. KMLA has gone through an unexplored reorganization period with the new headmaster, but students are confident that this transition will eventually lead to a great transformation. We, the editorial department, seek to drive positive changes in our school by covering the key issues of the first semester. These include EOP (English Only Policy), the Bamboo Forest, a potential shift from AP to IB, and being siblings in KMLA.

Not an April Fool's Joke: English Only Policy

Sangmin Lee

"Just Do It". Ever heard of it? It's Nike's famous catchphrase. Much like this, KMLA has an iconic symbol, one of its proud policies: the English Only Policy. Coincidentally, "just do it" perfectly summarizes the past attempts at EOP enforcement, which includes numerous policies bearing mixed results. When an unprecedented scale of sudden and extreme change was implemented to EOP on April 1st, unsurprisingly, students, as well as teachers, were not hesitant to voice objections. Problems were raised on multiple levels. What exactly happened, what went wrong, and where will EOP head to in the future?



The April 1st Policy Changes

On April 1st, the school put in place a strict penalty point system for English Only Policy (EOP). Students were mandated to speak English on weekdays from 8 am to 6 pm everywhere on campus except for the Minjok Education Building, dormitory, and teachers' classrooms. Each violation earned students 2 penalty points.
To add, a quota system was introduced: if weekly violations were less than forty, penalty points would be withdrawn, and reward points given to the non-violators.

Most importantly, the system was based on student-to-student prosecution, meaning students were tasked to prosecute other students. Those with this duty were mandated to display bold identifying signs on their backpacks and, if seen not prosecuting properly, penalized. The irony of this situation should not be lost on any casual purveyor of modern history.

Communication Breakdown

A fundamental problem separate from the policy altogether was the lack of any meaningful communication with the student body. It was even mentioned on the "Muk-sa-pal" Facebook group, in a post criticizing the new EOP changes.

"During the two months of discussion, not one person in the student body heard anything about EOP prosecutions," commented the Facebook post. "In no part of the process were our voices taken into account."

Due to this entire lack of communication, those who were unaware of the policy changes and the obscure, minor details of the regulations were made to pay the price. It also raised questions about the role of the newly emerging Student Council, which had promised active communication but failed to deliver in this case.

How Did "April 1st" Happen?

With a new semester arriving, along with the new headmaster, Dr. Park Ha-shik, the administration became enthusiastic about the enforcement of EOP. Numerous conversations were held between the EOP Department, administration, and the teacher in charge of EOP. The teacher, with the administration's support, pushed for a full-scale student-to-student prosecution method and dismissed any gradual implementations such as "EOP Day."

Not failing to spot a critical issue, the Student Council and EOP Department members raised concerns regarding the potential outlash that would possibly be directed at them. It was met with the teacher's comment that prosecution is on the school regulations and enforcement was non-negotiable.

Options like armbands, name tags, and vests were considered to identify EOP enforcers. During a discussion between the EOP members, the armbands were chosen, but this decision faced backlash due to its negative connotations. Several teachers voiced discomfort at the visual of the armbands. Students were then ordered to cut the armbands into rectangles and attach them to their backpacks instead.

During the entire process, red EOP posters displayed all around campus advertised the incoming changes. Few knew they foreshadowed the events that were to follow.

On April 1st, EOP began.

How It Played Out After the Policy

The new policy saw effect immediately. For the first time in what seemed like years, EOP was kept on a school-wide level. Concerns that students would only speak English in a jokingly manner were surprisingly met with authentic English communication, albeit from a relatively small proportion of students. The policy showed that many students were capable of communicating in English, in what was perhaps the biggest influence EOP had had in a long time.

Yet, to little surprise, the problems predicted during discussions all came true. Most students could not agree with the purpose of the policy and the severe restriction on the use of Korean. To those who could, the penalty system seemed too much. The students only expressed more outrage due to the ambiguity of the prosecution manual and the inconsistency of the prosecutors.

"I was prosecuted for speaking Korean, but the other students passing by and speaking Korean weren't," said Jahng Suh-Yoon, a junior.

The greater problem revealed itself on the prosecutor's side. They faced significant backlash and isolation as their peers avoided them to escape penalties. The problem was perhaps worsened due to the lack of communication; some believed it was the EOP Department that forwarded the change.

It went as far as school violence. Behind the backs of members, negative and often false rumors spread and there were attempts to keep EOP Department members out of friend groups.

The problems grew so extreme that an emergency discussion had to be held by the third day. A vote was held among the Student Council and EOP Department members, and it was decided that prosecutions should be stopped during the midterms. During this time, the Student Council would take time to communicate with the students, and the teachers would reach a unified consensus on their stance on EOP.

Communication, Resolvement, Moving On

The Legislative Council set out to actively pioneer changes after the midterm exams. During a special committee meeting held on April 21st, information and opinions were exchanged. Three conclusions were drawn: student-to-student prosecution had to be abolished, the teachers had to form a unified consensus on EOP, and the EOP Department would come up with friendlier ways to enforce the policy.

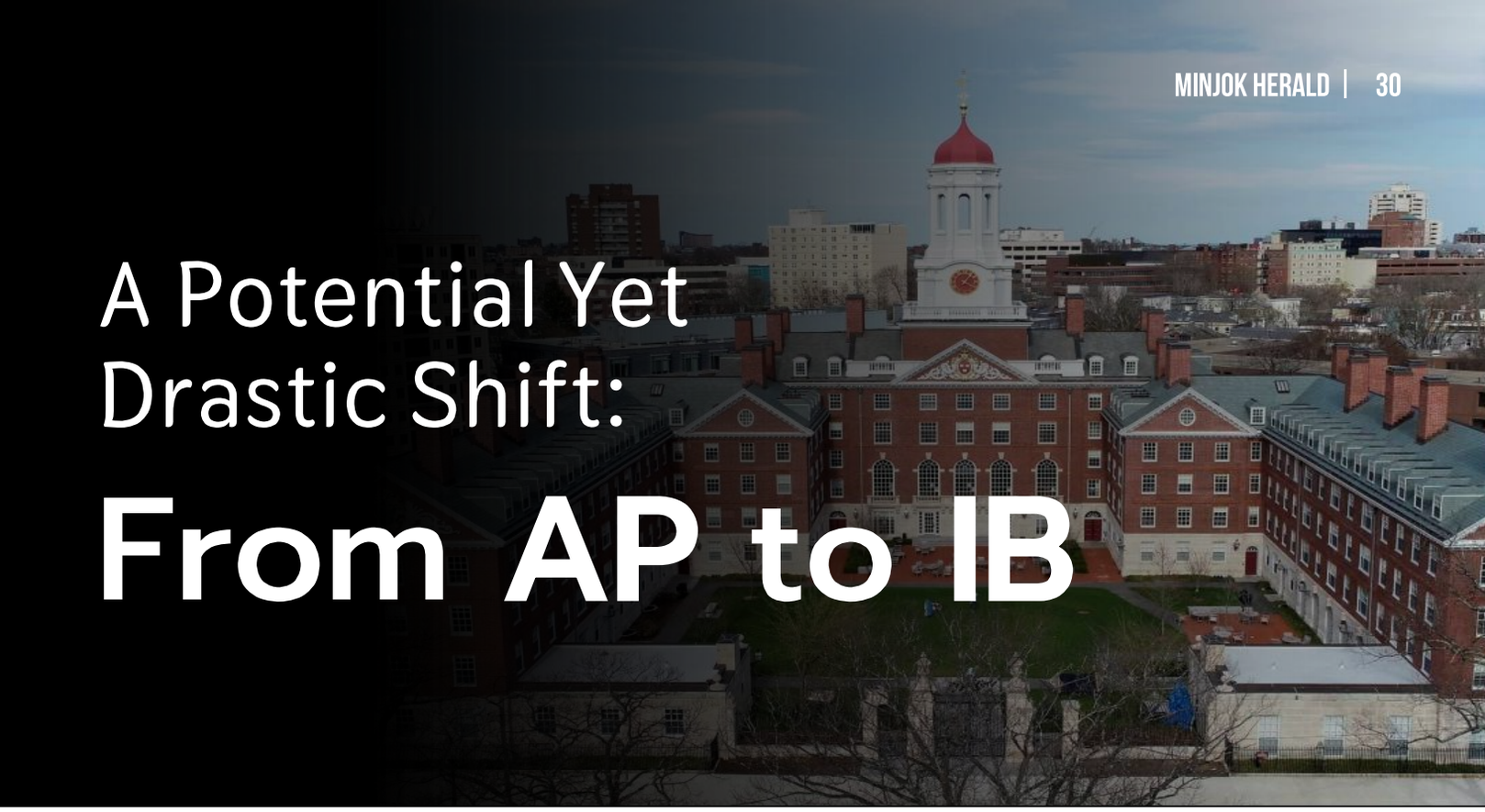
During the following week, teachers came to a conclusion that mostly aligned with the students' demands. Student-to-student prosecution was entirely abolished, and those who were caught violating the EOP regulation by the teachers could recite a "Speech of the Week" for the penalty points to be withdrawn.

Further steps were accomplished, thanks to the unified consensus formed among students. A bill was passed through the Legislative Council to completely remove student-to-student prosecution from the school regulations, which was successfully done.

The new policy brought mixed results, but its contribution to communication cannot be ignored. It brought teachers and students together to exchange opinions, and ultimately, to implement future changes upon a basis of active attention.

Conclusion

The initial implementation of the English Only Policy brought communication and execution issues to light. However, through active dialogue and cooperation, the school community is working towards a more effective and harmonious enforcement of EOP. The changes reflect a commitment to maintaining a positive learning environment while respecting the voices of both students and teachers.



A Potential Yet Drastic Shift:

From AP to IB

Seyoung Lim

University is a serious issue for all high schoolers, and KMLAians are no exception. Students, regardless of their field, strive daily for grades, club activities, exam scores, and winning projects in the hopes of gaining acceptance to their dream university or college.

Currently, KMLA hosts roughly 330 Domestic Field and 120 International Field students. As many are well aware, KMLA's international curriculum has its basis in the Advanced Placement (AP) curriculum that aims to assist students in gaining essential scores for their applications. Becoming an AP school in 2000, a part of KMLA's history that is always emphasised is that we were the first to adopt the system in South Korea, ushered in by none other than our new Headmaster, Dr. Ha-shik Park. At that time, he was serving as the school's Vice Principal as well as teacher (1997-2004), before leaving to continue a decorated career in education that included roles as principal in famous high schools, including Chungnam Samsung Highschool (CNSA), and Gyeonggi Academy of Foreign Languages (GAFL), where he established Korea's first International Baccalaureate Program (IB).

Now that he's returned to KMLA, intent to breathe new life into our curriculum, he's working towards the possibility of introducing IB here as well.

> The obvious questions are – what does this mean for our curriculum, especially concerning International Field students?

For KMLA students, the AP system is part of the school's fabric which we are all accustomed to by the time we are seniors. Every year, for the first two weeks in May, AP students all over the globe undertake the huge academic burden of writing AP Exams. Catering to students mainly targeting U.S. colleges, AP offers 39 exams in 39 subjects, ranging from Latin to Physics C: Mechanics. Students sit the exams for up to three and a half hours, and get scores that range from 1 to 5; with the minimum passing score being 3. KMLA students tend to be disappointed with anything less than 5, and seniors often debate over which scores to include in their Common Applications each October. This pattern and routine has embedded itself in KMLA for years and years, and the prospect of interrupting it, or at the very least including something new, has many teachers, parents, and students asking questions. Headmaster Park has been pleased to answer, leading discussions, delivering presentations, and gradually campaigning towards this yet-to-be fully-defined adjustment. So, what is IB?

Standing for International Baccalaureate, IB is an internationally acknowledged curriculum that can begin as early as pre-school and continue beyond high school. Specifically, what Headmaster Park seeks to implement is IBDP, the IB Diploma Programme, a two-year system for high schools all around the globe. Students who have completed the curriculum are reviewed with the same standards when applying for universities, regardless of their nationality or school location.

The curriculum is mainly divided into subjects from six groups and a DP Core. These six groups are composed of different fields of subjects, such as language, science, maths, and arts. A student must select one subject from each group. A Higher Level and a Standard Level course are provided for each subject. DB Core includes TOK, short for Theory of Knowledge, EE for Extensive Essay, and CAS for Creativity, Activity, and Service. TOK is a philosophical class that requires a presentation and an essay on each of the subjects one takes. EE is a 4000-word essay focused on a single subject, written over the course of a whole year. CAS is a similar activity to extracurriculars. All these academic works and activities are graded on a scale of full-point 45.

IB is generally recognised as a demanding programme that isn't easy to graduate from. Though not thoroughly explained, a glimpse of the effort needed can be seen from the above description. Beyond the challenges of completing the program itself, there's also the bigger challenge that the school faces in implementing it in the first place. Everyone taking part in the programme, from teachers to students, must have a high level of English skills. All the lectures must be done in English, and all assignments must be completed in English. The curriculum also mandates a strong interconnected bond between students, instructors, and the school management system.

> The above difficulties and plans for solutions were voiced in the below interview with Headmaster Park, who invited us to his office on May 28th.

MH:
KMLA has been mainly focusing on AP examinations until now. How will our education curriculum change if IB is implemented?

Park:
First of all, we haven't fully decided to adopt the IB system to KMLA yet. Since the understanding and cooperation of the faculty members must be prioritised when considering IB, we are currently discussing whether implementing the curriculum would benefit the school. I paved the road to implementation in other schools before coming here. I also wanted to take the system into KMLA since IB is an ideal educational curriculum–international, well-rounded, and professional–and also stresses a humanistic sense.
Currently, no school does all three systems at once: AP, IB, and the domestic track. The education board is aiming to construct a curriculum where students can also consider IB.

MH:
I was under the impression that schools had to implement the IB curriculum without any alterations since it is already designed as a holistic programme. How can AP and IB coexist in KMLA?

Park:
For elementary and middle schools, implementing IB indicates the whole student body is following the same system. However, for high schools, it is possible to adopt the curriculum partially. For instance, IB is already performed at GAFL and CNSA. They have 10 and 12 classes, respectively, but IB is carried out only in one class. IB doesn't have to be completely applied. As long as there is a single subject open per group, it can set off its course. So we're planning to go through a training period with teachers who volunteer in each of the six groups–starting small and going big. We will gradually expand the curriculum, not replacing the previous system at once.

MH:
It sounds like a steady approach. From what wave do you expect the system to fully settle in?

Park:
Schools should undergo at least a two-and-a-half-year period of preparation to be acknowledged and qualified as IB World Schools. Only after that can they educate students based on the curriculum. So even if we start now, I believe it'll be possible from the 32nd wave. 31st if lucky, but most probably 32nd.

MH:
I heard you contributed a great amount to implementing the AP system in KMLA. In your opinion, what advantages does IB have compared to AP?

Park:
Good question. When I first adopted AP into the school as a deputy headmaster, we benefited a lot from it. But other schools started to benchmark us after our achievements. Unlike KMLA, a boarding school, students in the schools in Seoul with the AP system had easier access to private tutoring. In a nutshell, there was a side effect of an increase in private tuition for AP. I pondered on the international-level education curriculum that tutoring wouldn't be of any use. And then, when I went to America to meet university admission officers, they mentioned the IB programme. They relied more on the grades and the IB evaluations than AP scores. That's when I first made a blueprint of it.

MH:
It surely is a beneficial programme, but a proficient level of English is required for the class to roll smoothly. Are there any difficulties you expect when IB is implemented?

Park:
There are teachers in subjects other than English who can conduct the class in English. They haven't been doing so since we didn't emphasise the necessity until now. Since we are aiming for partial application, I don't think it'll be much of a problem to secure a teacher from each of the main subjects. The only downside is that it will take some time, and the current students won't be able to experience the curriculum.

MH:
It will be a milestone for the future nonetheless. But then the students should also possess a sufficient level of English skills to follow the classes. I heard the interview format is changing greatly this year. Do you think we could select students with these skills?

Park:
Yes, because of that, even though we cannot keep our current interview style in the coming years, we plan to include some sort of method to check the English skills in the admission procedure.

MH:
Thanks for your time, and we look forward to more updates.

Unlike the rapid change of curriculum that many were expecting to occur, the headmaster stressed that the school is still at the kickoff level. He also informed that IB can first be partially implemented and gradually improve the system, taking a prolonged view. It seems KMLA will take a much more precautious approach to this issue than the previous attempts to adjust or change school curriculums.

However, though IB has the potential to offer tremendous help to international students with their intensive studies if well-adopted, some concerns still exist regarding the school environment. Not many can comprehend, composite, and express their feelings without a sense of unease, which is clearly evident from dozens of failed EOP policies over the decades of school history. Teachers, however well-trained they might become, can also feel burdensome to prepare classes, lead discussions, and invoke active participation in English since it is not their mother language.

The effect of the shift from AP to IB remains to be seen in the future. But this change will directly affect the international track students and also possibly the domestic as a side effect, one way or the other. Hence, we cannot deny that sincere consideration and the process of gathering opinions must precede any changes made. The Minjok Herald will continually explore and gather opinions on this issue to offer comprehensive analysis and commentary.

POV: You're a Sibling in KMLA

Seohyeon Choi

“See you after we’re adults,” was our crossed promise exchanged before my older brother, Choi Hyeon-Jun, Jun, entered KMLA. Little did I know that instead of meeting him after his graduation, I would see him every day as a fellow pupil at KMLA after two years. This brought both challenges and unique opportunities that shaped my high school experience. But what is it like to navigate this journey from both the younger and older sibling's perspectives?

POV: Being a Younger Sibling in KMLA

One of the most challenging aspects of having an older sibling at the same school is the high expectations. People often expect the younger sibling to excel in all aspects; academically, socially, and in extracurricular activities. Once, my favorite teacher jokingly said, “Hey, Jun’s sister! Today what fascinating thing are you going to do? Maybe look for some competitions as your brother did?” Although it was a joke, the fact that I was referred to as “Jun’s sister” instead of my name, coupled with the comparison to my brother, was disheartening. Wherever you go, the older sibling’s shadow always follows you.

Despite these drawbacks, I don’t regret being a younger sister in KMLA. The wealth of information and guidance they provide becomes a huge advantage.

As an international student in KMLA, I find there are various extracurricular activities, competitions, and in-school activities to do. Jun provided me with information on various competitions in which I could participate. Even though he majored in a completely different field, Jun helped me find intersections between our interests, such as volunteer work I could do.

Being a younger sibling in KMLA, you don’t just have an advantage in information, but the special experiences also strengthen the sibling bond. Woo Jung-won, who has a younger sister attending KMLA, made a speech about having confidence during Monday Morning Assembly by introducing a personal experience with his sister, Woo Jung-min. She shared, “It was amazing to be able to tell so many people, especially people I know, about my relationship with him. It was a time for me to reflect on the relationships and importance of my family.”

POV: Being an Older Sibling in KMLA

What is it like being the older sibling at KMLA? To gain insight, Minjok Herald (MH) interviewed Choi Hyeon-Jun and Woo Jeong-Won.

From the outset, it feels both strange and awkward to have a younger sibling attending the same school, even if you've shared the same elementary and middle school experiences. For Jun and Woo, seeing their sisters do well at KMLA–whether academically or socially– makes them feel proud.

Jun, as a freshman with insufficient information, wanted his sister to perform better than him. Having struggled in AP English Literature, he shared key points, such as important quotes from Walden by Henry Thoreau, to help me succeed.

Woo had a similar desire for his sister. In his words, "I wasn't good at French when I was a freshman. So I taught my sister French before she joined KMLA. I privately tutored her even before coming into KMLA about all the lessons in French and whatnot. Seeing her get the grades I wished for makes me proud that she fulfilled my dream."

There is an implicit responsibility that comes with being the older sibling. Jun acknowledged feeling a subconscious need to behave better and live more morally under the pressure of being a comparatively mature person. Having a sibling at KMLA expands the social network around you, making it easier for the younger sibling to blend into the community. However, as Woo shared, "it means that many people know more about you than you might be comfortable with."

Being siblings at KMLA is a unique journey that comes with both pressures and privileges. For younger siblings, it can be daunting to stand under the weight of expectations and constant comparisons, yet the insights and guidance from an older sibling are invaluable. Older siblings, on the other hand, feel the responsibility of setting a positive example and supporting their younger counterparts, which can be both fulfilling and challenging. This shared experience fosters a stronger sibling bond and prepares us for the future by teaching the importance of mutual support and respect.

Dear reader, what do you think it would be like for you to have a sibling in KMLA? Would it be a source of pressure, a wellspring of support, or perhaps a bit of both?

KMLA Bamboo Forest

: An Agora of KMLA, or a Ticking Timebomb?

Jeonggyeom Kuk

In Silla, there was a King Gyeongmun who had ears as long as a donkey's—a secret known only to his hat maker. The hat maker, burdened by this knowledge, shouted, "The king's ears are donkey ears!" in the bamboo forest near his home. This anecdote, recorded in the history book 'Samguk Yusa,' has become an internet concept. Various societies have constructed an online “Bamboo Forest,” a platform where people can post content without revealing their identity.

At the KMLA, there also exists a Bamboo Forest. Here, students share their writings, emotions, and criticism of the school system. The posts cover a wide range of topics, including personal reflections, praise for clubs or the Student Council, and even jokes. One of the main functions of the Bamboo Forest is to offer students consolation, encouragement, and a space for constructive debate. It also acts as a conduit for advice and guidance, connecting current students and graduates via Facebook Messenger. Freshmen gain information about past events and receive tips for school life. The platform fosters an environment where students learn to appreciate constructive criticism.

However, not all posts in the Bamboo Forest are positive. Many are critical or accusatory, sometimes mentioning specific names or leaving enough clues for the intended subjects to identify themselves. These critical posts exhibit a duality; while they may appear negative, they also prompt self-reflection among readers. Some students even humorously tag their roommates and offer apologies. Every society needs a space where anger can be expressed, and criticisms and accusations are not inherently harmful if they remain within respectful bounds. Unfortunately, several distressing posts have been shared on the Bamboo Forest, causing harm before being taken down.

In 2023, KMLA faced a severe issue of school violence, stemming from the cancellation of former NOI director Chung Sun-sin's appointment due to his son's school violence at KMLA. This incident has left the KMLA community haunted by the specter of school violence.

Given this context, the current situation where students feel aggrieved by accusations made in the Bamboo Forest poses a significant threat to the KMLA community. The Division of Student Affairs is monitoring the Bamboo Forest closely, and a teacher has warned that if the issues are not resolved, the platform may be shut down.

However, closing the Bamboo Forest is not a solution. It could lead to a backlash, such as outbursts, conflicts, and problems that are even harder to resolve. The 450 students at KMLA cohabit Deokgo House for three years, enduring daily stress from quizzes, exams, and various extracurricular activities. Thus, complaints and criticism are inevitable. Silencing these voices will not eliminate conflicts but cause them to fester until they explode in unforeseen ways, whether through secret Facebook accounts, in-person confrontations, or group chats.

Living in a sterile environment free of germs is not ideal. It's better to coexist with germs while building immunity. The same applies to KMLA. It is impossible to create a conflict-free environment, and students need to learn how to express conflicts appropriately. They must criticize without accusation and avoid attacking someone's character while pointing out mistakes.

While it is ideal for students to learn how to criticize properly, adjusting the environment itself by adopting the necessary systems is also crucial. Currently, the Bamboo Forest is managed by individuals who recklessly and unjustifiably bestow admin rights on close juniors without any legitimate standards. This has contributed to the decline of what was once a symbol of a fresh and green culture. There are alternatives, such as allowing the Student Council to control it or placing it under the Division of Student Affairs Director. Setting clear post-filtering standards and announcing them to all students can also be helpful. Reshaping the Bamboo Forest as a platform where students can enjoy themselves, seek help, express frustration acceptably, and embrace constructive criticism is essential.

We cannot ignore the positive functions of the KMLA Bamboo Forest. Even critical posts, if within proper bounds, are necessary. Therefore, students should actively participate in repairing the Bamboo Forest, rather than shutting it down, to make it a healthy outlet for emotions and opinions.

FEATURE

We live in an era where the boundaries between life on the screen and life in reality increasingly blur. As technology advances and becomes more intertwined with our daily existence, we evolve from mere "users" to inhabitants of the digital environments it creates. This transformation brings with it unprecedented opportunities and ethical dilemmas that challenge traditional moral standards. In this 70th edition, under the theme "Life in the Screen," we explore how ever-changing digital technology shapes life both within and beyond KMLA.

AI Influencer

From Algorithms to A-Listers :

Meet KMLA's New AI Influencer!

Seoeun Bae

Meet Rozy Oh, one of the most successful influencers in Korea, boasting over 17,000 followers and collaborating with major companies like Sinhan and Hera. Recently, she even graced the cover of W Concept magazine. In just a year, she has reportedly earned over 8.4 billion won. Anyone would naturally want to meet such a famous and successful person, but you can't. That's because she isn't real. She is South Korea's first virtual influencer. But what exactly are “virtual influencers,” and why are they rapidly gaining popularity? And can Nurungji, KMLA’s feline mascot, become a virtual influencer herself?

◀ AI Influencer 'Rozy Oh'

A virtual influencer is a computer-generated character designed to engage with audiences on social media platforms. These characters are usually fictional, yet they resemble human influencers. They are used in various content forms like social media posts and commercials to help companies connect with customers. The market for virtual influencers is projected to be worth over 37.8 billion USD by 2030, highlighting the growing significance of AI technology and virtual influencers in today's world.

The rise in popularity of virtual influencers is due to their unique characteristics compared to human influencers. Being computer-generated, they have no limits to their appearance, personality, or background. In other words, they can be tailored perfectly to meet specific needs. Additionally, virtual influencers offer greater availability. Unlike humans, they are not constrained by time or space, requiring only programming and design. A well-designed virtual influencer could potentially replace human influencers due to their versatility and cost-effectiveness.

Take Apoki, for instance. Apoki began as a virtual influencer aimed at kids. She looks like an adorable mix of a bunny and a human, appealing perfectly to her target audience. Not only this, a company could save up to $50,000 for a single campaign with her according to a calculation done considering the brand value and time spent creating the campaign. Now, she is one of the most successful AI influencers among the younger generation.

AI Influencer

▼ KMLA's New AI Influencer : Nurungji

Researching virtual influencers inspired me to create one for KMLA. Our school needs a solid marketing strategy, and I thought of using Nurungji, the stray cat introduced in our last edition. If you missed it (you totally should read it), she is a beloved stray cat adored by students and faculty alike, now living on campus with an endless supply of canned tuna and chur.

Given Nurungji's iconic status at KMLA, I decided to create an AI cat influencer for our school. The virtual cat, also named Nurungji, mirrors the original's fur and eyes. I generated several images of AI Nurungji and designed posters to be shared on Facebook.

Creating a virtual influencer was a challenging task. The freedom to create meant making many decisions. It required careful consideration of various elements like background, personality, and appearance. While creating Nurungji, I took her actual personality and habits into consideration. For example, her virtual self lies down whenever she sees any kind of sunlight and loves to be rubbed, just like our real-life Nurungji. Once Nurungji was created, producing content became easier than I anticipated. With Nurungji already in the digital world, I could simply add her digital image to any needed content.

I am confident that our new mascot, Nurungji, will significantly boost future KMLAians' interest in our school. However, I would love to hear our readers' opinions. What content should I create next with our new virtual influencer? Do you think she is charming enough to replace KMLA's outdated marketing strategies?

Neurons vs Bytes : Who wins?

Eva Yeda Moon

Smart. Efficient. Adaptive. Learning. Analytical.

These are the adjectives that describe AI nowadays. While they used to describe human intelligence, things have changed 180 degrees in the last few decades. Consequently, as the current era rapidly evolves, the prospect of careers being replaced by artificial intelligence is becoming more likely. Many people are afraid of such phenomena, forming the questionable notion that “AI’s abilities supersede human capabilities.” Yet we ought not to forget that humans are the ones who developed AI. So, how have we reached this far with AI technology? How is the mechanism of AI so powerful? It is primarily because AI’s inspiration was the human brain; AI copied your brain. Let us venture into the linkage between AI and the human brain and discover how to proceed.

Biological brains and AI have noticeable similarities. Firstly, AI’s neural structure imitates that of the human brain. The human brain is composed of billions of neurons that function 24/7; this very second, it’s allowing you to read and comprehend this article. Similarly, AI neural networks are constructed with layers of artificial neurons, known as nodes, which make data processing and operations possible.

Despite having similar operating units, brains and AI differ significantly. The human brain excels at generalization and abstract thinking from limited input, while AI relies on large datasets and extensive computational power. Crucially, the human brain is self-aware and creatively connects disparate concepts, whereas AI lacks consciousness and genuine creativity, merely generating outputs based on learned patterns. Humans are intricate and original, capable of exploring and creating new ideas, while AI passively follows orders without its own identity.

The critical contrast between the human brain and AI frequently uncovers itself in real life. A few years ago, the Henn-na Hotel in Japan attempted to implicate AI in their staff, but little did they know AI would create more work than achieve it. The robots struggled with understanding or responding to complex questions or requests, and in-room assistants frequently misinterpreted sounds and startled guests at night. The hotel ended up replacing more than half of its AI staff with humans.

In the realm of medical diagnosis, AI's limitations become clear even further. A 2020 Nature study documented an AI system designed for skin cancer detection failing to identify melanoma. The AI, trained in image analysis, missed the malignancy because it presented atypically. Similarly, a 2021 news report detailed a patient with a rare autoimmune disease receiving multiple misdiagnoses from AI tools. The uncommon nature of her symptoms confused the AI's database. These cases demonstrate that while AI excels at pattern recognition in large datasets, it can't compete with a doctor's ability to consider a patient's unique medical history, identify anomalies, and leverage experience and intuition to reach an accurate diagnosis.

On an extended note, Harvard Business Review states,

> ***"AI won't replace humans, but humans with AI will."***

To rephrase it, those who will prevail will be humans utilizing AI, not AI itself. However, even just recently, some KMLA teachers have banned the usage of AI tools such as ChatGPT despite its spiking popularity. The reason for such opposition is presumably out of the worry that students would overuse AI and abandon their originality–which is the most prominent upper hand we have over AI. Nevertheless, simply banning AI will do no good for the students in the long run. Instead, teaching how to utilize AI for rote tasks and not the thinking itself, is the direction the school should proceed in.

Some of the teachers in KMLA are already taking the steps to shift in that direction: starting from the 29th wave, students will learn how to implement generative AI in writing in both Korean and English classes. These classes will be the stepping stone for the students to become the humans utilizing AI. This unprecedented move is not an easy step to take. However, by embracing AI, KMLA is preparing its students to harness technology to enhance their productivity, rather than avoiding it out of fear of misuse. This shift will equip students with valuable skills, fostering a generation proficient in both traditional academic disciplines and the latest technological advancements. Thus, learning to appropriately utilize AI as a smart assistant is the way to go in such a time as this where AI's skillset is expanding every single day.

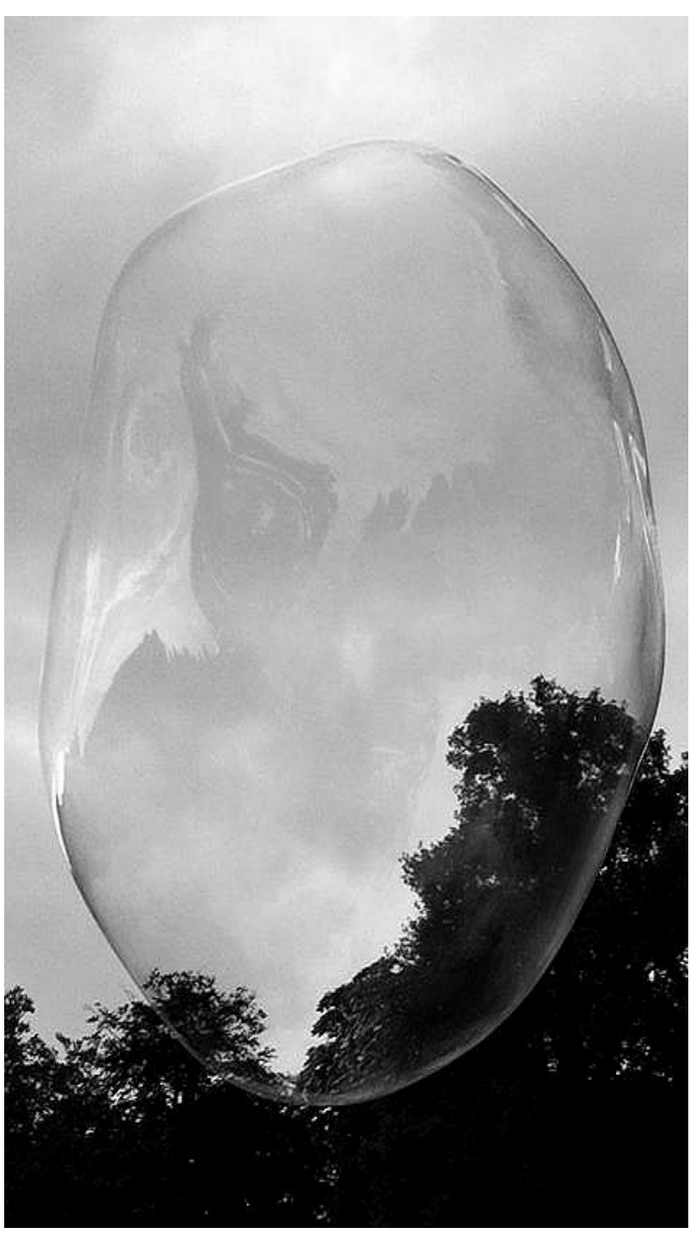
In conclusion, while AI advancements raise concerns about job displacement, it's essential to recognize the distinctive capabilities of the human brain that AI cannot replicate. Instead of fearing AI, we should leverage its strengths to complement our abilities. As future global leaders, the ability to incorporate the latest technology into our studies and lives is a crucial building block that will undoubtedly prove beneficial in our lives right now and so on.

HOW BUBBLES ARE BUILT AND BURST:

A Look Into Diversity in KMLA

Hyunseo Lee

What comes to your mind when thinking about diversity in KMLA? When KMLA students are asked what they like about their school, they often mention the environment that values diverse intellectual pursuits, academic fields, perspectives, and experiences compared to other Korean high schools. All of this holds true to some extent. But let us inquire further: Is that diversity comprehensive? Can we say there is enough diversity in many other areas? Looking into more factors may suggest otherwise.



One indisputable fact is that KMLA is among the most expensive high schools in Korea. Although the scholarship system has become more lax and accessible for students from low-income families in recent years, the vast majority of students still come from similarly affluent socioeconomic backgrounds. Likewise, there is a lack of diversity in the geographic regions students come from, not to mention race and ethnicity. For one, around 80% of the 29th wave come from Seoul or the provinces surrounding the capital, and the student body is predominantly Korean, with very few international or ethnically diverse students. Discussions on sexual minorities or the presence of people with disabilities are also noticeably absent. As a result, lack of inclusivity in the minority groups–groups of people we do not easily encounter on campus but very much exist outside of it–is what replaces these absences.

Considering all these factors reveals an irony. Despite the school's promotion and pursuit of diversity, it remains a largely homogenous environment with little prospect in the diverse makeup of the student body. Here, a crucial question arises: How does the lack of diversity in these fields impact the flow of information and the formation of beliefs within our school community? To answer this question, let us draw a parallel to a concept from the digital world: the "epistemic bubble."

What is an Epistemic Bubble?

Some readers will be familiar with similar concepts like "confirmatory bias" and "echo chambers." Though there are slight differences in the nuance of these words, they all conceptualize structures in which information flows and beliefs are formed. An epistemic bubble is a social structure where certain information is excluded, perhaps by mistake or systematically, leading to a skewed understanding of the world. This is a structure often seen online, where our confirmation bias and personalized algorithms limit exposure to diverse perspectives by filtering content to match our pre-existing beliefs.

The KMLA Bubble?

At KMLA, our close-knit and relatively homogenous community has the potential to inadvertently mirror this phenomenon. Members here at our school are often referred to as the "KMLA family." Whether individuals embrace this identity or not, the strong sense of connection and interdependence among students is a defining feature of our school. As we spend most of our semesters in the same environment, isolated from the outside world, the physical environment can function as an epistemic bubble where our cognitive landscape is limited to the group of people we meet on campus. In turn, it may restrict our approach when we view the world. Of course, some students actively try to overcome these limitations. Still, when we look around campus, not only is there a physical absence of minority groups, but we see a stark lack of inclusivity and open-minded perspectives toward them.

Why is Open-Mindedness Important?

You may still wonder: Why does any of this matter? What's the danger of living inside an epistemic bubble? One answer lies in our school's core mission: to cultivate global, creative, servant leaders who can impact the world in all walks of life. The school promotes leaders who are well-versed in social issues. Achieving this mission requires more than just a uniform student body coming from the same region and affluent backgrounds. Can these leaders be fostered without understanding and appreciation that goes beyond one's immediate environment? Will they be able to tackle these problems with an innovative approach in society? Or at least, live alongside the diversity with an open mind?

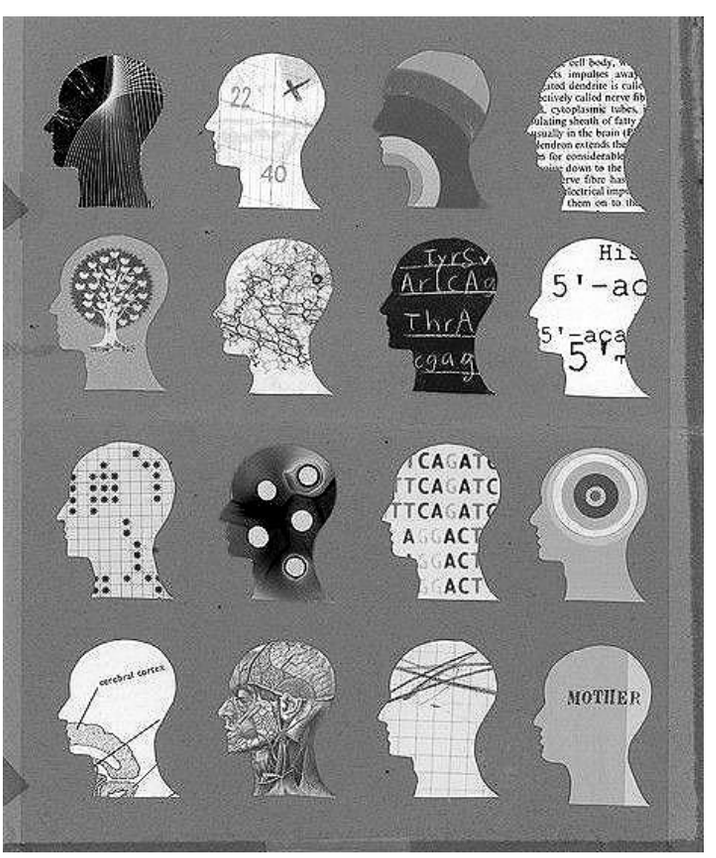
If this goal sounds too far-fetched or idealistic, let's consider another possible answer: Today, diversity, open-mindedness, and community engagement are valued by prestigious institutions worldwide; not just in academia but also in workplaces. Shouldn't we strive to keep pace with the world so that our students can flourish and lead in such diverse environments?

What Can KMLA Do Better?

There are a multitude of paths that we can take, for our school to become a more cognitively diverse society. One such path would be to diversify the student body. Recent changes in the admissions process could offer insight–but this is another huge topic for another article. Instead, a smaller, yet more feasible path we can take, is to diversify our source of information. Though some of this should be achieved through individual efforts, the school can prevent the systemic formation of an epistemic bubble. Our school could benefit from more programs that make valuable conscious connections with society, such as our cultural interactions with the Raffles Institution in Singapore. We need more opportunities where students are encouraged to extend their epistemic zone by putting themselves in a more diverse setting.

A look into diversity in KMLA shows that there is still much room for growth. Stephen Covey's words may resonate here:

"Strength lies in differences, not in similarities."



Making KMLA Greener :

Harnessing Technology for a Sustainable Future

Minju Kim

When driving into KMLA's campus for the first time, visitors might notice the solar panels next to the soccer field and gain a positive impression of our use of green energy. While most students and teachers have the belief that these panels aren't functioning, I was informed by KMLA's energy and safety manager, Mr. Lim Gyeungsu, that they generate about 50 kWh of electricity every hour. That’s roughly 2.5% of our total usage.

The sad news is that while we’re doing our part, human activities globally emit around 4.1 million metric tons of carbon dioxide into the atmosphere every hour. The good news? Technology is stepping up to help tackle these massive environmental challenges. From innovative renewable energy to promoting environmental issues in the digital space, the vast development of modern technologies is teaming up to address these urgent issues. But what can we do here at KMLA to contribute to a more sustainable future beyond our solar panels?

Let's start with artificial intelligence and advanced analytics. These tools can optimize energy use, predict demand, and find the best spots for renewable energy. Imagine AI telling us the perfect places for wind turbines or solar panels by analyzing geographical features. On a sunny day in the cafeteria, we can see the wind generators on Deokgo Mountain (now known as Mt. TaeGi) harnessing the natural power of the wind. Imagine knowing that a certain hill on campus is perfect for wind or solar power, maybe even better than Mt. TaeGi.

Social media is another powerful tool. At KMLA, our ‘En_Siders’ club uses platforms like Instagram to promote awareness and action among teenagers. They even hold annual conferences to engage students in solving environmental problems, all made possible through digital programs and devices. The global network enables us to contribute to a sustainable future, even from within Deokgo House.

KMLA has been using renewable energy since 2005. Our solar panels, now 19 years old, are still working efficiently, covering about 2.5% of our energy needs. They generate enough energy hourly to charge 80% of an average electric car, enabling it to run for 30-45 minutes. This might seem like a drop in a bucket for our large campus which houses more than 500 people, but it’s a meaningful start that we can improve.

What more can KMLA do to keep up with technological and environmental progress? I spoke with our school's energy and safety manager, Mr. Lim Gyeungsu. While there are no current plans to expand our infrastructure, he suggested that increasing our renewable energy sources could significantly lower our electricity costs and reduce our reliance on coal.

Here are some other ideas we could consider for KMLA, in the future:

1. **Distributed Generation**: This means generating energy close to where it's used, reducing the need for long-distance energy transport and making the system more efficient.

2. **Microgrid/Smart Grid**: These systems analyze the supply and demand of energy and distribute it so they can adapt to external conditions in the most efficient way possible.

These concepts might seem complex, but they represent exciting opportunities for those interested in innovative technologies. If you're curious, take a look at 'The Green School Bali,' supported by Huawei, which currently implements smart solar panels and smart grid systems and reduces 3.5 tons of carbon dioxide every month.

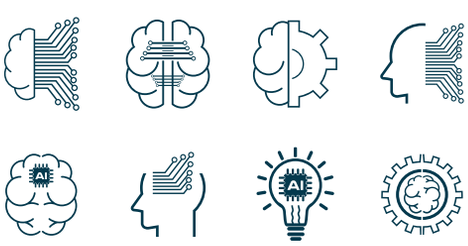
Our Role : Leading the Change

As future leaders, KMLA students need to stay updated on the latest environmental technologies and think about how we can participate in this positive change. Beyond just installing renewable energy systems, we have the creativity to come up with new ways to make our school greener and more sustainable. What ideas do you have? How can we, as a student body, make a difference?

KML-AI: The Future of Our Education

Seoeun Yang

Artificial Intelligence rules over the world. This concept is quite familiar, as it has been the plot of many science fiction movies from our youth. But now, AI has stepped out of the theater screens and into our lives; notably, our classrooms. The “AI Wave” is sweeping across many fields, and education - arguably one of the most crucial - is no exception. Revolution in how we teach and learn has begun, and AI has unlocked the door to limitless possibilities in education (and some might argue, limitless issues). As with any new and powerful technology, we must examine how to use it efficiently rather than hastily.



While human teachers will always possess the human touch that is essential in shaping young minds, there is no doubt that the standardization of AI has some advantages. By analyzing each student’s individual progress and identifying areas for improvement, AI can personalize learning experiences by adapting to each student's pace and learning style. Also, unlike human teachers, AI can answer questions students may have at any time of day without any hesitations, providing support outside of the classroom. Furthermore, AI can assist teachers by automating tasks such as grading, tracking attendance, and scheduling, thereby freeing them up for more interaction and human connection.

So what might an “AI teacher” look like? Meet Jill Watson, a teaching assistant at Georgia Tech. Her job is to assist students by answering their questions on the course discussion forum. What students had yet to know was that Jill Watson wasn’t human; she was an AI. Created by Professor Ashok Goel and his team, the project aimed to explore the potential of artificial intelligence in supporting educational processes. It was a success, as Jill accurately and efficiently assisted students with their inquiries. The project highlighted the potential for the use of AI in educational settings, particularly in providing support for large online courses.

At first glance, KMLA’s learning environment may seem quite distant from AI integration. However, a closer look reveals a different story. Take a step into one of our classrooms, Mr. Garrioch’s American Literature class, where students are assigned to use AI. And no, it’s not students gathering info from ChatGPT for their essays. Rather, students are tasked with creative challenges that encourage them to express their thoughts and ideas with the help of AI.

As an example, Mr. Garrioch asked students to choose a stage of the Hero's Journey from Edgar Allen Poe's short story, "Masque of the Red Death," and then generate an image that captures the story's essence in AI-generated images. It might sound simple, but the results shared during class reflect that some students understand the stories more deeply than others, and also utilize the AI tools more effectively through what they enter. Not just images, Mr. Garrioch assigned students to create short AI-generated songs about a story of their choice, and sharing sessions during class show how students can use AI in creative ways to represent a character, theme, or event from the story. A song with a mysterious air, rhythmic drums, and a hint of a subtle flute can be created after reading an excerpt from Nathaniel Hawthorne's "Young Goodman Brown." In this class, the students are handed a new set of tools to express and explore their creativity, and at times it seems writing essays would require less effort.

Can KMLA take this further? What might the future hold? One significant issue at KMLA is its lack of accessibility. Beyond the geographical challenges, the school currently lacks tools to support students with disabilities. This is where AI can make a substantial impact. For instance, implementing AI technology that transcribes speech-to-text in real-time can support students with hearing impairments, while text-to-speech technology can assist visually impaired students. Through this, we would be taking a step closer to making KMLA a more inclusive and accessible environment for all students.

Moreover, AI learning platforms tailored to KMLA's needs could revolutionize student engagement and support. Why not create a Jill Watson of our own? This innovation would allow students to ask questions and turn to AI for help during self-study periods. The Know How Do How, a guidebook for students that has now become a long-time tradition, can be brought onto a digital platform managed by AI and therefore help guide students more efficiently.

KMLA's future with AI learning is far from certain, yet change is inevitable, and the responsibility lies within the members to decide whether or not to embrace the change and use it to enhance the way we learn. Nelson Mandela said, "Education is the most powerful weapon which you can use to change the world," and thus, to students seeking to become global leaders, integrating AI into their education may not simply be a source of aid, but a mandatory tool.

Minjok Herald